

One for the album: Germany secured its record-extending eighth title, triumphing over Spain 3-2 in a shootout after the match ended in a one-all stalemate.

expanded 24-team league stage also gave many up-and-coming sides a taste of the world stage.

Oman finished bottom of the pile in its maiden appearance, conceding 48 goals across its six matches. The side, which was brought in as a last-minute replacement for Pakistan, will take home an abundance of lessons but also a slice of history — captain Alhussin Al Hasni scoring the country's first World Cup goal, against Egypt.

"The biggest thing in sport is to show up," head coach Mohammed Jandal Bait said. "Sport is about winning and losing, but it is also about building character. I have seen small improvements in my players in every match."

Namibia, another tournament debutant, endured a rollercoaster of emotions. Johann Weyhe's side was trounced by both Spain and Belgium in Pool D but managed to beat continental rival Egypt to earn its maiden win.

A gut-wrenching shootout loss to Austria, followed by another defeat to Canada, meant that it finished 23rd. "It was an interesting tournament. The environment definitely tested us. There's a lot we can take back home and show the younger guys looking to play the next World Cup," skipper John-Paul Britz said.

FIH president Tayyab Ikram's decision to incorporate a Challenger Trophy for teams playing the 17th-24th classification matches provided them with an extra injection of zest.

It was no surprise then that teams like Austria and Canada put their best foot forward in these knockout matches.

Austria, which qualified through



the second division of the EuroHockey Championship, won back-to-back play-off matches via shootouts thanks to the exploits of custodian Lorenz Breiteneker, but fell at the final hurdle to Bangladesh, a side that gave Australia and France a tough run in the league stage.

"I think we've been playing better as the tournament has progressed. Extending the tournament to 24 teams has allowed us to play the best teams, and our boys have

realised they are not far off," said Bangladesh head coach Siegfried Aikman, who has made a habit of improving lesser-heralded teams, following his achievements with Japan (Asian Games gold in 2018) and Oman (bronze at the 2024 Hockey 5s World Cup).

Tournament top-scorer Amirul Islam (18 goals), with his lanky frame, fuzzy hair and venomous drag-flick, turned out to be a fan favourite in Madurai.